

By now, you are probably wondering why I am listing out all these issues, apparently unrelated to Moodle, since Moodle is a learning management system (LMS). But you will be surprised to discover that the majority of these issues were resolved by adopting Moodle! Surprising? I'll dwell on how this happened, below.

Moodle to the rescue!

After giving you an idea of the depth of our problems, let me tell you how I was introduced to Moodle. In 2008, one of our faculty members, R K Singal, assistant dean, Management, visited Vancouver Island University along with students of our PGDM course for the PDD program. On their return, my colleague told me that the entire university runs on Moodle. I thought, "Why not experiment with it?" I downloaded it and tried to install it. Initially, I could not understand anything about it, but I gradually got accustomed to it. It was easy to install on my own system, on XAMPP (<http://www.apachefriends.org/en/xampp.html>). At last, I had a solution to our problems!

As I started working with the software, it gave me ideas about how to solve the obstacles we were facing. Let me put down each of the problems, and the corresponding solution derived from Moodle, in case you face similar problems and want to use the same approach.

Paper notices and omitted email recipients

Manually putting notices on notice boards (for students) and sending notices/circulars (to faculty members) was a significant waste of paper and time, apart from occasionally forgetting to add some people as recipients. Moodle has a forum feature (see <http://docs.moodle.org/en/forum>). We use forums as notice boards for our major departments, uploading all notices and circulars to them. We ask students, faculty members and staff members to subscribe themselves to relevant notice-board forum(s). Moodle automatically sends mails to subscribed members, whenever a new circular/notice is uploaded. We don't have to remember to mail everyone, nor do we have to make the effort to address mails to hundreds of recipients.

Tracking constantly changing student email IDs

The solution to this problem was Google Apps (<http://www.google.com/a/help/intl/en/edu/>). We registered a new domain, inmantec-cms.org. We then registered it on Google Apps for Education, which gave us the freedom to create and manage email IDs for our students on Google servers. We asked students to set up 'mail forwarding' from their own personal IDs to inmantec-cms.org by amending some settings in their personal Gmail accounts. They now only use mail IDs that we have given them, with no loss of their personal mails. If they forget their passwords (which is quite rare), we are there to help them out.

This mail option was also implemented so that we could activate email-based self-registration in Moodle. Now



Figure 1: Cartoon

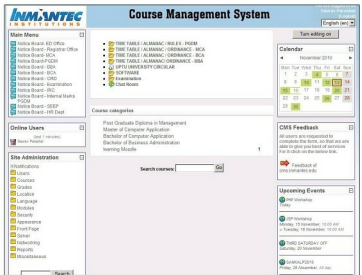


Figure 2: Notice board

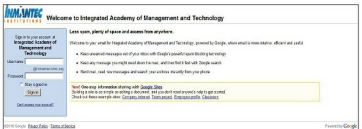


Figure 3: Google Apps

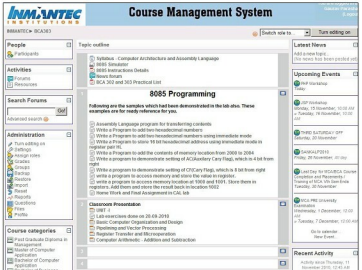


Figure 4: Course Homepage

no one else, other than students and faculty members of Inmantec, can create their accounts on our Moodle site—because we have activated only two domains, inmantec.edu and inmantec-cms.org.